

PARADISE

THE NEW TOURIST GAZE

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PART I CONSTRUCTING

OTRA, EY PERO NO HAY BODA TITÍ ME PREGUNTÓ SI TENGO MUCHA' NOVIA' MUCHA' NOVIA' HOY TENGO A UNA, MAÑANA OTRA ME LAS

Paradise begins with distance. It needs an elsewhere: a place imagined as warmer, cleaner, slower, more generous and more available than the space from which the traveller departs. This elsewhere has never been neutral. It has been assembled through maps, colonial expeditions, missionary accounts, ethnographic displays, postcards, cinema, advertising, resort architecture and, later, the endless circulation of digital images.

Each medium renews the same promise: somewhere outside the exhausted modern world, nature remains intact, time moves differently, bodies are freer, and social life appears without conflict. Paradise is therefore not the opposite of modernity. It is one of modernity's most persistent fantasies about itself. It offers escape from the very systems that produce it: industrial fatigue, colonial expansion, urban density, wage labour, ecological extraction, image saturation. Its function is not simply to show beauty, but to make beauty appear detached from history. The beach is not a coastline shaped by property law, climate, pressure, labour, migration and local use; it becomes an empty foreground. The island is not a political territory; it becomes a mood.

VO A LLEVAR A TOA' PA UN VIP, UN VIP, EY, SALUDEN A TITÍ VAMO A TIRARNO UN SELFIE, SAY

The village is not a lived social structure; it becomes texture. The landscape is not inhabited; it is offered. The colonial genealogy of this fantasy matters because paradise was never only aesthetic. It helped legitimise possession. To describe a place as unspoiled is often to erase those who have already shaped, cultivated and governed it. To call nature pure is to remove labour from landscape and history from ecology. To frame an island as empty is to prepare it for extraction, settlement, plantation, military occupation, resort development or real-estate speculation. The paradise image has repeatedly performed this double act: it intensifies the visibility of nature while weakening the political visibility of local people. What remains is a beautiful image structured by disappearance. In this sense, the postcard is not a minor object. It is a condensed visual technology. Its front turns place into surface; its back organises address, message, stamp and circulation. The destination becomes portable, transferable, possessed for a moment and sent elsewhere as proof.

The postcard's brevity is part of its force. It has no space for contradiction. It can carry a sunset, a beach, a monument, a costume, a smiling face, but not a land diary LES METÍ EN UN VIP, UN VIP EY, SALUDEN A TITÍ VAMO A TIRARNO UN SELFIE, SAY

spute, a housing crisis, a water shortage, a military history, a labour regime or an eviction. It teaches the viewer that the place can be consumed without the conditions that make it consumable. The same logic survives beyond the postcard. The contemporary tourist image is still built on selective emptiness. It depends on predictable chromatic values: turquoise water, white facades, blue skies, sand, green palms, gold light. It depends on compositional habits: the horizon line, the balcony view, the aerial beach, the infinity pool, the body turned away from the camera, the street that seems ancient but clean, inhabited but not crowded, authentic but not politically demanding. It depends, above all, on omission. Waste, infrastructure, fatigue, maintenance, service entrances, informal housing, queues, security barriers, cruise terminals and exhausted workers remain outside the frame. This visual grammar is powerful because it is instantly readable. A palm tree becomes tropical availability. A whitewashed terrace becomes Mediterranean purity. A narrow alley becomes authenticity.

A hammock becomes suspended time. An empty be-

BEYOND TOURIST GAZES ANDPERFORMANCES: U.S. CONSUMPTION OF LAND AND LABOR IN PUERTO RICAN AND MEXICAN DESTINATIONS

ALICIA SWORDS AND RONALD L. MIZ

A TITÍ VAMO A TIRARNO UN SELFIE, SAY «CHEESE» EY QUE SONRÍAN LAS QUE

Both critics (activists and posttourist advocates) and promoters (from the UN's World Tourism Organization (WTO) to local politicians and industry boosters) view tourism and colonialism qua development as inextricably linked. In absolute figures, worldwide earnings from international tourism reached a new record value of US\$682 billion in 2005. The tourism industry accounts for 6–30 percent, depending on how it is measured, of the world's exports of goods and services (WTO, 2006). It contributes increasingly to many nation-state economies, but the receipts accrued do not necessarily translate into increased standards of living: "Tourism becomes just another commodity, albeit a large one, for consumption, and thus part of the world market".

There is a large body of research on the geography and anthropology of tourism. The theoretical explanation by Urry suggests the degree to which consumption practices shape the production of tourist destinations. Drawing on Foucault's notion of the "medical gaze," Urry identifies what he calls the "tourist gaze": "Tourist experiences involve some aspect or element that induces pleasurable experiences which, by comparison with the everyday, are out of the ordinary." Importantly, the features identified by Urry are derived from the tourist's perspective.² For example, "the places gazed upon are for purposes not directly connected with paid work and they normally offer some distinctive contrasts with work (both paid and unpaid)". From the tourist's perspective, tourism involves liberation from the duties of home and work. From the hospitality worker's perspective, however, tourism is a central place of work. Tourism is a set of social relations in which the leisure of one party depends on another's servile labor. For example, child care is increasingly being displaced onto hospitality workers so that parents can enjoy their vacation, relax, and abandon all their responsibilities, including parenting. Their release from work could not take place without the provision of services to tourists.

We propose to focus on the relations of production and consumption that make the tourist gaze possible. The gaze is managed by hospitality workers as one of many roles they are expected to perform. Visual consumption is important, to be sure, on the basis for it is the material consumption of labor. The doorman, waitress, bartender, tour guide, taxi driver, entertainer, night attendant, and showgirl are service roles created for consumption by tourists. It is helpful to consider these roles performed to cater to tourists' whims. Desmond, analyzing the cultural performances of Hawaiian identity for mainland tourists, finds that "when all of these possibilities for encounter with the performance of Hawaiiana are taken into account, the probability is that most visitors to Waikiki will experience this enactment of Hawaiian-ness framed by the touristic discourse of soft primitivism and feminized sexuality." Analyzing performance without considering consumption seems to miss the exploitative aspects of these asymmetrical relations. Furthermore, viewing performance without accounting for the reproduction of labor—the conditions of child care, nutrition, housing, transportation, and basic needs of worker and family—blinds us to the daily existence behind the performance. We are interested in the ways in which tourism as a development strategy builds upon existing colonial and trade development practices.

land and labor relations. Building on the work of Marxist geographers who study landscapes as an expression of the relationship between geography and history, we examine the way tourism transforms landscapes. David Harvey examines the spatial dimensions of Marx's theory of capitalist accumulation: "The emergence of a distinct spatial structure with the rise of capitalism is not a contradiction-free process.... The landscape which capitalism creates is also seen as the locus of tension and contradiction, rather than as an expression of harmonious equilibrium." Harvey argues that difference is created and engraved on landscapes. "Difference and otherness are produced in space through the simple logic of uneven capital investment, a proliferating geographic division of labor, an increasing segmentation of reproductive activities, and the rise of spatially-ordered (often segregated) social distinctions". We find that the tourism industry has significantly altered labor relations, corporatized property, and increased dependence on informal labor as an active strategy of local entrepreneurs for securing a small portion of the receipts from the multinational mass tourism industry. In the past century, Puerto Rico has been transformed from a colonial agricultural outpost to a tourist resort. Particularly in the past several decades, tourism has dramatically transformed landscapes and the social geography of the island. The United States assumed control of Puerto Rico when the colony passed from Spanish to U.S. hands as a result of the Spanish-American War of 1898. By the 1920s tourists could travel from New York to San Juan by steamship for \$75, and by the early 1930s San Juan had two foreign-owned hotels, a few restaurants, and several nightclubs and casinos.

U.S. government officials first promoted mass tourism in Puerto Rico in the 1930s as an avenue for recovery from the Depression and as a centerpiece for U.S.-led economic development in the region. After 1944, land reform emphasized land for the landless, as well as industrialization, nation building, and the dismantling of the sugar plantation economy. The modernization campaign of "Operation Bootstrap" focused on industrialization and facilitated foreign investment while providing urban employment opportunities in the burgeoning factory and pharmaceutical production centers. The tourism industry took its cues from the modernization campaign in packaging the sugar plantation past, the Spanish colonial legacy, and commodities such as rum to draw U.S. tourists to the island.

In the late 1950s, 250,000 U.S. tourists annually visited Puerto Rico. By the mid 1960s, after the Cuban Revolution, 500,000 U.S. tourists arrived annually, making Puerto Rico the Caribbean's most visited island. In the early 1960s Americans spent US\$3 billion each year traveling overseas. In 2004 U.S. expenditures increased in terms of dollars spent on tourism, with a total of US\$69.6 billion.

Labor relations in Puerto Rico have shifted from a colonial to a neocolonial form, characterized by an ongoing mix of concurrent postcapitalist and premodern forms of labor". Pantojas-García describes the situation as one of peripheral postindustrialization. Until the 1970s the Puerto Rican development model depended on U.S. capital for export manufacturing and required migration to alleviate unemployment so that agribusiness and export industry could survive. By the mid 1970s competition for the island from the 1980s, Puerto Rico was no longer attractive, since U.S. minimum-wage laws applied there, and a "high-finance" development strategy was adopted that emphasized tourism and tax shelters for transnational capital.

Tourism has become one of the main service sectors in Puerto Rico, with 20,000 people employed in the hotel industry. For every 100 jobs in hotels, some economists estimate that 178 are employed in related activities (U.S. Census, 1999). It is difficult to find exact figures on the number of workers in the tourism industry, although data on tourist arrivals and the money they spend are readily available. Most hospitality workers are included in the U.S. census measures of service occupations and in the arts, entertainment, recreation, accommodation, and food services industry. There was a significant increase in the numbers in both categories between 2000 and 2005 (from 65,657 to 226,249 in the former and from 66,873 to 94,001 in the latter). The U.S. Census reports that nearly 60 percent of the Puerto Rican population over the age of 16 is not in the formal paid labor force, and almost 45 percent of the island's families live below the federally defined poverty line. These data must be viewed in relation to the data on tourist receipts, because the claim by industry boosters is that tourism is a financial benefit if not a panacea for developing nations and colonies. In 2004 Puerto Rico had totaled 3.5 million visitors, and the receipts generated from this tourism amounted to US\$3,024 billion. The sheer scale of tourism is awe-inspiring, but as the U.S. Census measures of socioeconomic status show, the funds are not trickling down to the vast majority of the population. Tourism on the island of Puerto Rico is of three main types.⁴ The first is the beach resort, a form that tends to monopolize the coastal real estate of the San Juan metropolitan area but is increasingly present in every coastal region. The second is Old San Juan, where a tour of the city is often

«CHEESE» QUE SONRÍAN LAS QUE YA SE OLVIDA-

	Indicator
1990	Lowest vulnerability
1995	State of built-up areas
2000	Change in built-up areas
2005	Population change index
2010	Built-up within protected areas
2015	Built-up growth within protected areas
2020	Available agricultural land
2025	Agricultural cultivation
2030	Loss of agricultural land
2035	Large-scale tourism
2040	Medium-scale tourism
2045	Loss of agricultural land
2050	Loss of agricultural land